

INFILTRATE THE ANIMAL MASQUERADE

For months, Dougan Mulch, the famed wizard detective, has been investigating an illegal traveling exotic animal market. Disguised as a masquerade, it's host to some of the most rapacious, gluttonous, and cruel members of Capital's upper crust. Dougan recently got access to one of their floor shows but revealed his identity in the process. Now he needs someone to infiltrate the show in his place and expose the corrupt noble at the heart of it using his invention the "Arcane Oculus," a magic eye which can record and project up to three images.

You can use one of the following hooks for this encounter, replacing any of the named concepts with elements from your own campaign:

Answered Ad. The heroes answered an ad looking specifically for "Morally upstanding" people with "non-descript faces." Just weird enough to be intriguing.

A Favor Owed. In his youth, Dougan was a cellmate of one of the heroes when both were jailed for unjustified reasons. His clever togue got them both released and he's calling in that favor they owe him.

(Bad) Meat's Back on the Menu. A rash of food poisonings at high end taverns has set Capital ablaze with gossip. Dougan takes advantage of the hubbub to contact the heroes and explain the situation.

Case of the Masked Ringmaster

This encounter assumes that the heroes have been contracted by Dougan Mulch and given the password, "Obsequious," to enter the party. He also gave them each an exotic animal mask to wear, as is customary. He also knows the Ringmaster will be wearing lion mask this month.

They'll have to blend into a party full of cutthroat and vicious nobles, create distractions to pass through restricted areas, and ultimately unmask and capture an image of the corrupt ringmaster, a prominent and powerful figure within Capital.

Setting the Scene

The heroes will be undercover. Before entering and detailing the party, have each hero describe their attire and what sort of animal mask they are wearing.

- ♦ "In the heart of Castorgate lies an iron door at the end of an alley wedged between two tall buildings. A small panel in the door slides aside, revealing the hairy face of a gorilla. "Password?" they ask, mouth unmoving."

The guard waits until one of the heroes provides the password "Obsequious."

- ♦ "The door creaks open to reveal a nearly seven-foot tall, muscle-bound goon in a tuxedo, a gorilla mask, and a vest made from a real gorilla chest. He stretches his long arm down a darkened hallway, where light faintly glimmers through a set of double doors."
- ♦ "The doors open to bright lights and the loud calls of a hundred different animals rarely heard in the same place."
- ♦ "The massive hall is full of cages, handlers, buyers, and hundreds of exotic endangered animals. The surroundings are opulent, while the animals' conditions are neglectful and cruel."
- ♦ "A small group of grumbling socialites mill near a roped off hallway leading out of the main hall. Another large masked goon stands guard over the exclusive area."

Encounter Credits

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Moderate Montage Test

If the heroes succeed, they'll be able to unmask the Ringmaster and capture his image with the Arcane Oculus. But before they can do that they'll need to pick him out of a crowd, create distractions, capture additional evidence, and then they'll need to escape with their lives.

◆ Unmasking the Ringmaster Test Difficulty ◆

Heroes	Success Limit	Failure Limit
3	4	2
4	5	3
5	6	4
6	7	5

Montage Test Challenges

The following challenges can be part of the montage test. Reaching the success limit does not end the test, nor can heroes achieve any higher than a partial success unless they successfully complete the Arcane Exposé challenge:

Maneuver by Merchants: Merchants hawking everything from exotic animals to mysterious meats to snake oil tinctures make it difficult to navigate the party.

Suggested Characteristics: Might, Agility, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Endurance, Hide, Intimidate, Sneak.

Acquire "Leverage": A small restaurant is serving up exotic meats while gluttonous nobles dine, unmasked. A perfect opportunity to capture incidental evidence and gain access to the restricted areas.

Suggested Characteristics: Agility, Intuition, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Conceal Object, Hide, Perform, Search.

Obtain Exclusive Masks: The heroes need new masks to access more exclusive areas and find themselves following a group that just left one of these zones.

Suggested Characteristics: Agility, Might, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Intimidate, Disguise, Pick Pocket, Track.

Securing Egress: Determine the best course of exit after the ringmaster is exposed and all eyes are on the heroes.

Suggested Characteristics: Might, Reason, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Endurance, Intimidate, Strategy, Track.

Unleash the Rage in the Cage: Innumerable fierce animals and beasts wait to be released into the crowds. Not a bad distraction.

Suggested Characteristics: Agility, Reason, Intuition.

Suggested Skills: Escape Artist, Handle Animals, Monsters, Nature, Pick Lock, Sabotage.

Note: Successfully completing this challenge will put the Ringmaster on high alert if he isn't already. Tests made to expose the Ringmaster will take a bane.

Upon completing either the Acquire “Leverage”, Obtain Exclusive Masks, or Unleash the Rage in the Cage challenges, the heroes gain access to the restricted areas and following challenges become available.

Find the King: The Ringmaster is one of many patrons in the restricted areas wearing a lion mask. Unmasking the wrong lion could be disastrous.

Suggested Characteristic: Reason, Intuition, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Alertness, Interrogate, Search, Eavesdrop, Read Person.

Split the Pride: Separating all the lion faces crowding the floor will be necessary if the heroes want to get a clear shot of the Ringmaster.

Suggested Characteristic: Might, Intuition, Presence.

Suggested Skills: Intimidate, Perform, Society, Strategy, Flirt.

Note: Successfully completing this challenge grants an edge on tests made to expose the Ringmaster.

Arcane Exposé: Either all the pieces are in place, or it's now or never.

The heroes attempt to unmask the Ringmaster.

Special: Tests made to expose the Ringmaster take a bane until the Find the King challenge is completed.

Suggested Characteristics: Might, Agility, Reason.

Suggested Skills: Endurance, Intimidate, Pickpocket, Strategy.

Note: Failing this challenge will put the Ringmaster on high alert if he isn't already. Tests made to expose the Ringmaster will take a bane.

Montage Test Outcomes

The montage test has the following outcomes:

Total Success: The heroes exposed the Ringmaster, the powerful noble Phinneas Glurch, and escaped without exposing themselves. The heroes earn 2 Victories each.

Partial Success: The heroes exposed the Ringmaster as Phinneas Glurch, but were unmasked in their escape. The heroes earn 1 Victory each and all have targets on their backs.

Total Failure: The heroes either unmasked the wrong lion or the patrons figured out the heroes were here, forcing them to flee.

Rewards

The heroes can earn the following reward:

Title: Ringbreaker

Prerequisites: Earn a total success on the encounter.

Effect: You have an edge on tests made to interact with animals.

Title: Exposed!

Prerequisites: Earn a total failure on the encounter.

Effect: You have a Bane on any negotiation roll with the nobility in Capital. You can complete the Community Service or Go Undercover downtime projects to clear your names and remove this title.

